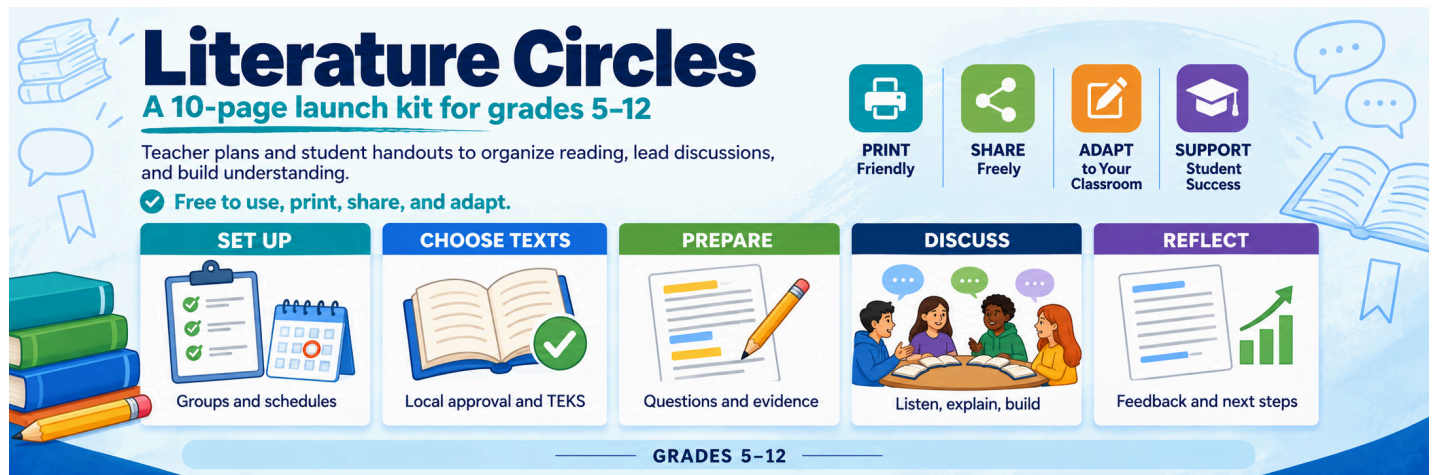


Literature Circles Launch Kit

Teacher instructions and student handouts



A practical plan for organizing shared reading, launching student-led discussions, and checking individual understanding.

Miguel Guhlin · mguhlin.org

mguhlin@tcea.org

blog.tcea.org

Inside: 10 pages of teacher guidance and reusable student forms, with Texas ELAR TEKS, local text approval, Reciprocal Teaching, optional Jigsaw, and an Aesop practice reading.

13-page PDF: cover + 10-page instructional kit + two optional organizers. Print student handouts using the kit page numbers in the footer (PDF page number is one higher).

Launch literature circles



Clear the reading → Form groups → Schedule meetings

Grades 5–12 · Small groups, shared reading, student-led meaning making.

Start tomorrow: Clear the practice text (p. 2), copy pp. 5–9, form groups of four, and run the 45-minute launch on p. 4. No devices or purchased books are required for the practice lesson.

What makes it a literature circle?

Students read a common text within their group, bring their own questions, and build interpretations together. Offer choices from locally approved readings when possible. Different groups may read different texts, or the same text. Roles support conversation; everyone reads and interprets the whole assigned section.

Before students arrive

- Choose one reading goal and its TEKS (p. 3). Example: explain how choices reveal a theme, using two details.
- Provide one text per reader, pencils, timer, group folder, and accessible versions. Print teacher pp. 1–4 and 10 once; pp. 5 and 8 once per group; pp. 6, 7, and 9 once per student.
- Group 3–5 readers by interest and access needs. Avoid permanent ability labels. Seat groups so everyone can see one another; reserve a conference spot.
- Set reading chunks at meaningful breaks, meeting dates, in-class reading time, and an absence plan. Check access before assigning home reading.
- Model a short discussion, then collect each student's own response. Coach groups while students lead.

Your 10-page toolkit

Teacher pages	Student and group copies
1 Launch checklist	5 Group agreement and reading calendar
2 Text selection and approval	6 Individual reading preparation
3 TEKS planning map	7 Rotating roles and talk moves
4 Schedule and facilitation	8 Meeting agenda and record
10 Assessment, troubleshooting, sources	9 Practice reading and independent response

Make learning visible

Learning intention: We are learning to build and revise interpretations together. **Success criteria:** I bring a question, explain relevant text evidence, respond to a peer, and identify how my thinking changed. Share these before every meeting; use p. 10 to give one specific next step.

Choose and clear the reading



Preview the exact text → Confirm access and approval → Plan the calendar

Approval is local. The suggestions below are candidates, not a Texas-approved title list. Use your school/district's current selection process, curriculum list, and required family notification. Public-domain status does not establish instructional approval.

Screen the exact edition or excerpt

Read the selection fully. Check developmental fit, complexity, cultural context, stereotypes or dated language, sensitive content, curriculum purpose, and discussion potential. Confirm legal copies and accessibility for every reader. Record any required approval and an equivalent alternate reading before offering choices. Consult your librarian or curriculum lead when status is uncertain.

Candidate / suggested band	Why consider it / preview first
Aesop, "The North Wind and the Sun" 5–12: launch practice	Short, low-barrier fable; choices, power, persuasion. Older readers critique the moral and whose viewpoint is missing. Retelling on p. 9.
Frances Hodgson Burnett, <i>The Secret Garden</i> (1911) 5–7: selected chapters or novel	Character change and belonging; preview colonial attitudes, racist language, disability portrayal, and death.
Louisa May Alcott, <i>Little Women</i> (1868–69) 7–9: selected chapters or novel	Family, ambition, conflict; preview gender expectations, religious references, illness, and death.
O. Henry, "The Gift of the Magi" (1905) 7–10: short story	Irony and sacrifice; preview dated vocabulary, poverty, and Christmas context.
Frederick Douglass, <i>Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass</i> (1845) 9–12: selected chapters	Literacy, voice, and freedom; plan context and support for accounts of enslavement, violence, and racist language.

Original works above are public domain in the United States; modern translations, introductions, illustrations, and annotations may have separate rights. These bands are starting points for teacher review, not reading-level guarantees. A locally approved contemporary text or nonfiction reading may replace any candidate.

Our locally approved menu — complete before launch

Title / author / edition / section	Approval source, reviewer, date	Copies, access, alternate

Instructional purpose / family communication required and completed: _____

Plan from the TEKS

Use the row for the enrolled grade/course, select a narrow target, and collect the evidence shown below. Codes refer to subsection (b) of the cited rule. Descriptions are planning paraphrases. A discussion format alone does not demonstrate mastery.

Grade / rule	Collaboration	Comprehension / response	Literary focus
5 · §110.7	1(D): shared responsibilities	6(B,F,I): questions, inference, monitoring; 7(C,D): evidence, summary	8(A): multiple themes within a text
6 · §110.22	1(D): student-led talk, notes, agreement/disagreement	5(B,F,I); 6(C,D): questions, inference, monitoring, evidence, summary	7(A): multiple themes within/across texts
7 · §110.23	1(D): meaningful discourse; constructive feedback	5(B,F,I); 6(C,D): same focus areas as grade 6	7(A): multiple themes within/across texts
8 · §110.24	1(D): agendas, goals, deadlines, roles	5(B,F,I); 6(C,D): same focus areas as grade 6	7(A): theme through characters/events
English I · §110.36	1(D): build on ideas and reach decisions	4(B,F,I); 5(C,D): questions, inference, monitoring, commentary, summary	6(A): theme through characterization/plot
English II · §110.37	1(D): build on ideas and reach decisions	4(B,F,I); 5(C,D): interpretive commentary and summary	6(A): theme; cross-cultural comparison
English III · §110.38	1(D): purposeful ideas; evaluate teamwork	4(B,F,I); 5(C,D): analytic commentary and summary	6(A): relationships among literary elements
English IV · §110.39	1(D): purposeful ideas; evaluate teamwork	4(B,F,I); 5(C,D): evaluative commentary and summary	6(A): relationships among literary elements

Match the target to observable evidence

- **Collaboration:** p. 5 responsibilities + p. 8 agenda; teacher records a student's response to a peer.
- **Comprehension:** p. 6 question, supported inference, and repair strategy; predictions must be revisited.
- **Response:** p. 9 individual claim, evidence, and explanation; p. 8 accurate group summary.
- **Literary analysis:** extend p. 9 using the chosen grade/course focus. Add a second approved text for an across-text target; a single fable cannot meet every listed expectation.

For nonfiction: retain collaboration/comprehension/response targets; replace the literary focus with your course's informational or argumentative-text expectation. High school alignment follows course enrollment, not grade number alone.

My target code: _____ Learning intention: _____

Evidence I will collect: _____

Verified September 16, 2026 against TEA Chapter 110, Subchapters A–C. Official links and research sources are on p. 10.

Run the launch and the cycle



Home group → Expert groups → Return home and connect ideas

First meeting: 45 minutes with the p. 9 fable

Time	Teacher and student actions
0–5	State the goal and success criteria (p. 1). Explain norms and show a text-supported response.
5–12	Read p. 9; pause before paragraph 3 to predict. Students reread and begin p. 6.
12–18	Model question → clarification → evidence → summary. Think aloud about revising a prediction. Invite two students to respond.
18–23	Groups complete p. 5 and assign p. 7 roles. Each student prepares a question and evidence.
23–40	Students run p. 8's 17-minute agenda. Visit two groups; note evidence and coach one talk move.
40–45	Each student completes p. 9's exit response. Give a next step and set the next reading deadline.

Reusable two-week cycle: five 45-minute lessons

1: Model and practice; offer the locally approved menu and form groups. **2:** Read chunk 1 in class (20 min), prepare (8), meet (17). **3:** Repeat for chunk 2; conference with different groups. **4:** Repeat for chunk 3; use optional Jigsaw only when helpful. **5:** Finish reading, meet, write an individual synthesis, and reflect. For novels, repeat lessons 2–4 until the text is finished; enter actual dates and sections on p. 5.

Reciprocal Teaching: a comprehension scaffold

Explicitly model **predicting, questioning, clarifying, and summarizing**; guide practice, then transfer leadership. Rotate leadership at a section break or next meeting. Each student uses all four strategies on p. 6; p. 7 assigns who starts each move. Predict before reading the next section, then confirm or revise. Use clarification when meaning breaks down. Let students' questions drive interpretation after the comprehension check.

Optional Jigsaw: deepen, then return to the circle

Use only after everyone has read the same selection and groups can talk productively. Assign each home-group member a lens: character choices, language, plot, or theme. Meet in same-lens expert groups (6 min); find two details and agree on an explanation. Use Appendix A to prepare expert notes and Appendix B to record home-group reports and quick-writes. Teacher checks accuracy. Return home (8 min); each expert teaches while peers question and record evidence. Each student writes how two lenses connect (3 min). Substitute this 17-minute block for one meeting. With three readers combine plot/theme; with five add point of view.

Jigsaw should enrich shared reading. Avoid dividing unread novel chapters among experts: every reader needs the story context. Fade role sheets as students independently use the strategies; keep preparation and individual evidence.

Our circle agreement and calendar

Group: _____ Class / period: _____ Date: _____

Text / author / edition: _____

Our learning goal: _____

Agree before you begin

Check each agreement together. Add one norm your group needs.

- ☐ We read the whole assigned section and bring p. 6, our text, and a pencil.
- ☐ We invite every member, allow thinking time, and listen without interrupting.
- ☐ We discuss the text and ideas respectfully. Nobody must share personal experiences.
- ☐ We give page/paragraph evidence and consider more than one interpretation.
- ☐ We stay within the assigned section to avoid spoilers and finish with a next step.
- ☐ We ask the teacher for help when our agreed repair steps do not work.

Our added norm: _____

Members and first meeting jobs

Member	First job (p. 7)	Access/support needed (optional)

Reading and meeting calendar — confirm with teacher

Meeting date	Read through (chapter/pages/paragraphs)	In-class reading time / next leader

If someone is absent or behind

The folder stays at: _____ Our catch-up time is: _____

The teacher provides the reading and notes. A returning reader reviews p. 8 and prepares a question. A reader who is behind uses a short reread with support before joining; peers do not complete that reader's work. Reassign an absent member's job temporarily.

We agree (initials): _____ Teacher check: _____

Read, prepare, and bring evidence

Name: _____ Group: _____ Meeting date: _____
Text / assigned section: _____

Everyone prepares. Read the entire assigned section. Write brief notes below; your job does not limit your thinking. Use chapter/page or paragraph numbers from your edition.

1 • Predict, then revisit

Before reading or at a stopping point: What might happen or develop? What clue supports it?

After reading: My prediction was confirmed / revised because...

2 • Ask an open question

Ask about a choice, conflict, idea, or author's craft. It should invite explanation and allow more than one reasonable interpretation. "Why might...?" or "How does...?"

3 • Clarify a difficulty

Confusing word, passage, or idea + location: _____
Repair used: ☐ reread ☐ context clues ☐ glossary/resource ☐ ask for help
Now I understand... / I still need help with...

4 • Summarize the essentials

In 2–3 sentences, explain the key events or ideas accurately and in order. Keep your opinion separate.

5 • Bring two details and an interpretation

Location + short quotation or accurate paraphrase	What it suggests / why it matters

My first idea about the theme, central idea, or author's choice: _____

Ready check: ☐ Reading completed ☐ Question ready ☐ Evidence located ☐ Support requested if needed

Rotate leadership; share the thinking



Locate a passage → Ask and clarify → Compare evidence → Summarize

Assign who starts each move. Everyone may question, clarify, summarize, predict, and interpret. Rotate jobs one position each meeting. With three members combine Summarizer and Predictor; with five add an Evidence Tracker to note locations on p. 8.

Job	What to do	Try saying...
Questioner / facilitator	Open with the learning goal. Invite each reader's question; help select one worth exploring. Invite quieter voices and watch time.	"Which question will help us understand this section?" "Would you like to add, read your note, or pass for now?"
Clarifier	Invite difficulties. Lead a reread; use context or a resource. Check whether the explanation fits the passage.	"Where did meaning break down?" "Let's reread before and after that line."
Summarizer / recorder	Give a brief accurate section summary. After discussion, record the group's interpretation, evidence, disagreement, and next step on p. 8.	"The essential events or ideas are..." "We agree on... but still differ about..."
Predictor / timekeeper	Revisit earlier predictions. Use a clue to predict the next section before reading it. Announce agenda transitions and confirm the deadline.	"Our earlier prediction changed because..." "This clue makes me expect..."

Talk moves that build an interpretation

- **Locate:** "In paragraph/page ____, the text says/shows..."
- **Explain:** "That matters because..."
- **Build:** "Adding to your idea, another detail is..."
- **Test:** "Does that explanation fit this other passage?"
- **Disagree respectfully:** "I read it differently because..."
- **Revise:** "I first thought... Now I think... because..."

When the conversation stalls

Pause for 30 seconds of writing. Reread one short passage. Invite a question from each reader. Choose one question and compare two possible answers using the text. If disagreement continues, record both supported views; you do not have to force consensus.

Roles are temporary scaffolds. When your group uses these moves without reminders, ask the teacher to use a shared agenda instead of assigned roles. Keep the same reading and evidence expectations.

My job this meeting: _____ Next meeting: _____
One talk move I will practice: _____

Meeting agenda and group record



Bring evidence → Invite questions → Build an interpretation → Record next steps

Group: _____ Date: _____ Text / section: _____

Present: _____ Absent / temporary job changes: _____

Today's learning goal: _____

Follow this 17-minute agenda

Minutes	Action
0–2	Check materials and goal. Give the short summary; revisit an earlier prediction.
2–5	Invite every reader's question or difficulty. Clarify by rereading and select a focus question.
5–12	Explore that question. Each reader contributes evidence or responds to a peer; compare interpretations. Include anyone who passed earlier.
12–15	Record a supported interpretation and an unresolved question. Predict the next section if there is one; otherwise identify a new question.
15–17	Self-check; set reading deadline and rotate jobs. Return the folder; write the individual exit response as directed.

Our focus question

What we now think and what supports it

Interpretation / explanation	Two text locations and supporting details

A different supported view or unresolved question:

Participation and next steps

Members who contributed evidence or responded to an idea (initials): _____

How we invited others / support we need: _____

Next prediction + clue OR new question: _____

Read through: _____ Due: _____ Next job rotation: _____

Group check: ☐ We used evidence ☐ We considered another view ☐ We know our next step

One improvement for next time: _____

This record supports reflection. The teacher assesses each student's understanding using individual work and observation.

Practice with a public-domain fable



Read closely → Test an interpretation → Explain evidence → Write your response

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group: _____

The North Wind and the Sun

An original classroom retelling of Aesop's public-domain fable, based on *The Aesop for Children* (1919). Paragraph numbers support evidence citations. This is an adaptation, not a quotation of the historical edition.

1. The North Wind and the Sun argued about which of them was stronger. As they argued, a traveler appeared on the road, wrapped in a cloak. They agreed on a test: whoever could make the traveler remove the cloak would win.
 2. The North Wind went first. He blew a cold blast toward the traveler. The traveler pulled the cloak tightly around his body. The Wind blew harder and harder, but each gust made the traveler hold on more firmly. At last the Wind stopped.
- Pause:** What might the Sun do? Write a prediction and clue on p. 6 before continuing.
3. The Sun began to shine gently. The traveler loosened the cloak as the air grew warmer. Then the Sun shone more brightly. Feeling hot, the traveler took off the cloak. The Sun had won the test.

Vocabulary: cloak = loose outer garment; gust = sudden strong rush of wind.

Discussion invitation: What does this contest suggest about influence? Does winning this test prove who is stronger?

Choose the teacher-assigned challenge

Grades 5–6: Compare the characters' actions; propose two possible lessons supported by details. **7–8:** Explain how the sequence of events develops a theme and test another interpretation. **9–10:** Analyze characterization and contrast; question the contest's definition of strength. **11–12:** Evaluate how viewpoint, plot, and characterization shape the message; consider the traveler's missing perspective. The fable is practice; transfer to a sufficiently complex approved text.

Independent exit response — after discussion

Make a claim answering your challenge. Use two paragraph references and explain how each detail supports your claim. Include an alternative interpretation or a limitation when appropriate.

My thinking changed / became clearer because... (identify a peer idea or passage)

Self-check: ☐ Clear claim ☐ Two details + locations ☐ Explanation ☐ Reflection

My next step: _____

Assess, adjust, and keep going

Use a brief individual evidence check

Use pp. 6 and 9 plus your observations. For each dimension mark **2 = independent and accurate**; **1 = partial or needs prompting**; **0 = not yet shown**. Reassess after feedback. Adapt scoring to local policy; do not substitute a group score for individual understanding.

Dimension	Evidence for a 2
Preparation / comprehension	Accurate summary, meaningful question, and a useful clarification or prediction revision.
Interpretation / evidence	Defensible claim; two relevant details with locations; explanation connects details to the claim.
Collaboration	Builds on or tests a peer's idea respectfully; helps others participate using the agreed norms.
Reflection / transfer	Identifies what clarified or changed thinking and chooses a specific next step.

Feedback example: “You located two details. Next, explain why the traveler's tighter grip challenges the Wind's idea of strength.” **Practice response:** Gentle influence can work where force fails: in ¶2 stronger gusts make the traveler grip the cloak; in ¶3 warmth leads him to remove it. Another reading is that success depends on the task, not absolute strength. Accept different supported claims; do not require one moral.

Common problems → practical repairs

Unfinished reading: provide supported in-class catch-up and adjust chunk size. **One voice dominates:** use a brief round, then open discussion. **Silence:** silent notes, partner rehearsal, then reread. **Unsupported opinions:** ask for a location and explanation. **Confusion:** model one repair strategy and check again. **Off-task conflict:** restate the norm; conference or regroup when needed.

Access: honor IEP/504 and language supports. Offer audio with text, larger print, vocabulary preview, bilingual notes, speech-to-text or an oral exit response. Keep the interpretive goal. Do not equate speech volume or speed with understanding. After two meetings, review student evidence and revise supports, pacing, or grouping.

Sources, scope, and reuse

Official TEKS: TEA Chapter 110 (tea.texas.gov → Laws and Rules → Chapter 110), Subchapter A, B, and C; verified Sept. 16, 2026. Fable source: Project Gutenberg #19994, *The Aesop for Children* (1919), public domain in the USA.

Strategy references: Visible Learning MetaX, Reciprocal teaching and Jigsaw method (visiblelearningmetax.com → Influences). The classroom routines here are adaptations; research averages do not guarantee a particular class outcome.

Additional organizer reference: Miguel Guhlin's *Copy of Notes Organizer v3* (two-page teacher-supplied PDF); appendices adapt its 3–2–1, questions/vocabulary, Jigsaw notes, and quick-write structure for literature circles.

Planning references: the four PDFs in the local litcircles folder (College Board implementation guidance and role-sheet/checklist packets credited to their original providers). This kit uses original wording and layouts; no reference worksheet or artwork is reproduced. Not affiliated with TEA or Visible Learning.

© 2026 TCEA • Created by Miguel Guhlin • Kit content CC BY-NC 4.0; code MIT. The underlying Aesop fable remains public domain. Reuse details: mglearn.github.io/printables/licensing.html.

3–2–1 reading notes

Name: _____ Date: _____ Home group: _____

Text / section: _____ Expert lens (if used): _____

Read the whole section first. Write or draw three important ideas, two supporting details with locations, and one summary in your own words. Record questions and vocabulary alongside your notes. Use this instead of p. 6 when your teacher assigns it, or to prepare for an expert group.

Questions

What needs clarification?
What could the group explore?

3 • Important ideas

Character choices, conflicts, themes, or central ideas.

1.

2.

3.

Vocabulary

Word + location + meaning or clue.
Mark anything still uncertain.

2 • Supporting details

Short quote or accurate paraphrase + page/paragraph + what it shows.

1.

2.

1 • Summary in my own words

State the key events or ideas accurately and in order. Keep interpretation separate.

Bring to the circle: Star one idea worth discussing and one detail that supports it.

My interpretation: These details suggest _____

After discussion: My thinking changed / became clearer because _____



Notice ideas → Locate evidence → Summarize → Discuss

Jigsaw notes and quick-write

Name: _____ Date: _____ Home group: _____
Text / section: _____ My expert lens: _____

Expert group: Prepare Organizer A for your assigned lens. Compare evidence and check your explanation with the teacher. **Home group:** Each expert teaches; everyone listens, asks a question, and records the rows below. **Quick-write:** After each report, write or sketch how that lens deepens your interpretation. Prioritize ideas over spelling.

Expert lens + notes from the report Include an idea and its text location.	My quick-write / question Connect the report to the text or another lens.
1 · Lens: _____	How does this help explain the reading?
2 · Lens: _____	What connects to or challenges an earlier idea?
3 · Lens: _____	What does this add to our interpretation?
4 · Lens: _____	What question or alternative view remains?

Four rows allow notes from your own lens and three others. With five readers, combine related lenses in a row or continue on the back. Use character choices, language, plot, theme, or point of view; for nonfiction use central idea, structure, evidence, and author's perspective.

Independent synthesis — connect at least two lenses

My interpretation is... Two lenses connect because... The supporting text locations are...

Check: ☐ I can explain another lens ☐ I used text evidence ☐ I wrote my own synthesis

Next step / unresolved question: _____



Learn with experts → Teach your home group → Write your own synthesis